Zimmerstrasse as they stalked the Wall's emergent path. Freed meandered through parked army tanks and jeeps, GIs squatting with trays of fast food, and pedestrians passing through a then-makeshift but heavily guarded Checkpoint Charlie on Friedrichstrasse. On August 27 he and Oltmans crossed the city's internal border to East Berlin, traveling down the monumental boulevard of Stalin Allee and into the Oberschöneweide neighborhood, where they sat with workers on a terrace and visited a bookstore. Later that day, back in West Berlin, Freed and Oltmans witnessed a frenzied evening scene on Moritzplatz in which U.S. military tanks with searchlights, joined by jeeps equipped with speakers, blasted Elvis Presley music near the border wall to galvanize throngs of West Berliners who had gathered to protest the still-fresh physical division of the city.[4]

Freed confronted his visions of a war-prone Germany in the American sector of a newly walled Berlin, and through his own directed movement, he pursued his own circuit of alternative cultural diplomacy. In doing so, he examined American power along the border and reflected on his own expatriate status. He traveled to divided Berlin to comprehend the ways Jewish history was present within a city experiencing a new wave of division. But in the majority of his images from this trip, the new wall is barely visible. Instead American GIs stationed by the border receive his most consistent and direct focus. Many of the soldiers barely acknowledge Freed's presence, while others cast sidelong glances at him and his camera.

There is one exception to this indirect viewpoint, when Freed faced head-on both the Berlin Wall and a fellow American in the same frame. The resulting image would haunt Freed, beckon his return from exile, remind the expatriate of his American whiteness, and transform his practice as a photographer. Here, at the nascent wall, Freed snapped a photograph of an unnamed black soldier standing at the edge of the American sector (fig. 1.1).[5] After lifting his finger from the shutter release, he left the scene without taking any more photographs. Freed's contact sheets from this trip confirm that, unlike his other GI images at the Wall in which he sometimes captured the same serviceman from several angles, this soldier image was a single shot.[6]

Taken at middle distance in black and white, the frontal portrait features the uniformed soldier in the foreground, his eyes cast downward and to the side. Freed stands near the intersection of Zimmerstrasse and Charlottenstrasse streets, between trolley tracks that dead-end in the